AN INDEPENDENT PROJECT BY THACH NGUYEN

The ceremonies arrived. The decisions did not.

Four familiar Agile values, each paired with a practical correction.

TAKE THIS INTO THE NEXT MEETING What decision did we make, who owns the next step, and what support do they need?

Read before you sprint

Agile gave teams useful ways to inspect work, learn, and adapt. Those ideas need more than a board and a calendar. People need clear decisions, evidence they can question, and room to act on what they learn.

frAGILE looks at the distance between the ritual and the work. Below are four familiar Agile values after a trip through the org chart. The distortions are ours, not quotations from the original Manifesto for Agile Software Development (agilemanifesto.org).

Four values, distorted

I. Individuals and interactions

THE DISTORTION Everyone leaves the meeting feeling heard. The decision leaves with nobody.

WHAT HOLDS UP Name the decision, who makes it, who takes the next step, and what support is needed. Kindness includes clarity.

II. Working software

THE DISTORTION The document is approved. The product is still a promise.

WHAT HOLDS UP Record the decision, its rationale, and the constraints the next person must respect. Documentation earns its place when it helps someone act or protects quality. Show the working thing, too.

III. Customer collaboration

THE DISTORTION The loudest request wins, then gets described as customer-led.

WHAT HOLDS UP Bring current customer evidence into the decision. If safety, policy, or other constraints point elsewhere, record the trade-off and who made it.

IV. Responding to change

THE DISTORTION Every change is called a pivot. Nobody can name the evidence that moved the plan.

WHAT HOLDS UP Name the new evidence, the work that stops, who decides, and when the new direction will be reviewed.

Six principles worth keeping

01 **A polished status update cannot make unfinished work usable.** Show the work.

02 **Before making feedback actionable, make it safe to give.**

03 **When the burndown is green and the team is worried, investigate the gap.**

04 **A pivot should retire some work.** Otherwise it is a new label on the same backlog.

05 **Culture appears when someone brings bad news.** Watch what happens next.

06 **Every blocker has a story.** Listen before fixing.

Name the pattern. Change the work.

No certificates. No maturity model. No transformational lanyard. Pick one recurring practice this week and ask what decision, learning, or protection it is meant to provide. If the answer is unclear, make its purpose explicit or change the practice. Name who will take the change forward and when the team will check whether it helped.

A five-minute decision check

After one recurring meeting this week, write down what changed and what will happen next.

DECISION MADE OR LEARNING GAINED

NEXT STEP AND OWNER

SUPPORT OR CONSTRAINT TO ADDRESS

WHEN WE WILL CHECK WHETHER IT HELPED